

Privacy bill heard

(N.Z. Press Association)

WELLINGTON,
July 25.

A bill providing for a commissioner who would protect the privacy of the individual was introduced in Parliament today by the Minister of Justice (Dr Finlay).

The Privacy Commissioner Bill, one of four given urgency today, provides for the appointment of a privacy commissioner on the recommendation of the Minister of Justice, who will inquire into any matter or procedure which seems to him to infringe an individual's privacy.

He will also report to the Minister from time to time on the desirability of taking legislative, administrative, or other action to give protection or better protection to the privacy of the individual.

Dr Finlay said that the commissioner was not to be considered as a privacy ombudsman and he would not inquire into individual complaints. It had been decided not to establish a definition of privacy because of the difficulty of defining what privacy was.

Mr P. I. Wilkinson (Nat., Rodney) said he was disappointed that a statutory definition of privacy had not been established and Mr D.

S. Thomson (Nat., Stratford) said it seemed in some ways an ominous bill which could install "an inquisition."

'IMPORTANT'

Mr G. F. Gair (Nat., North Shore) said the measure was by far the most important of the three introduced to the House during the day by the Government.

"I'm less happy with it than with the others. There seems a real danger that rather than protect privacy it might invade it. Can the Minister define what privacy is?"

Dr Finlay said he hoped that there would be some legislative action taken next year in relation to credit bureaux. It had not been possible to introduce it during this session of Parliament.

The privacy commissioner would report only to the Minister of Justice and he believed that this ensured protection against any undesirable spread of private information.

There was no power in the measure for an investigation of individuals and he believed Mr Gair was not correct in his claim that the bill could lead to an invasion of privacy.

But, he said, there was difficulty in defining privacy in legal terms.

The bill was referred to the Statutes Revision Committee.

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